

A HOUSEHOLD CORRECTION

I RETURNED HOME FROM CHICAGO IN WORSE SHAPE THAN EVER, Angstrom's loss eclipsed by my having dropped several thousand on the ill-fated Loews options in a matter of days. Thankfully, my wife continued to make a decent living in real estate, and had also taken care of the children, while I'd fallen deeper into this hole. Although she didn't know the half of it, I did. This self-knowledge had profound effects on the politics in the house.

In periods when there's some profit on paper—in my case, as far back as the first weeks—the investor in the family is infused with uncharacteristic generosity and does suspicious things, such as buying champagne, encouraging the family members to go shopping, and taking them to restaurants normally off the budgetary limits. These spasms of largess baffle those recipients who are accustomed to Scroogian economics from the investor. Earlier, I mentioned my having bought extra Christmas presents during the brief but happy Brigadoon of Angstrom's being up. Naturally, the family distrusted these gifts and wondered if I'd lost my mind.

The generosity lasts only as long as the paper profits, and then there's the great comeuppance. Not only has the investor suffered investment losses, but he has also run up big credit-card bills on the expectation of gains that lately have vanished. This is a frightening realization, which sends the investor cowering to the side of economic austerity and turns him into a penny-pincher.

For instance, after my retreat from Chicago, I wandered about the house turning off lights and muttering about the electric bill. I complained about the 15-cent charge for calling the operator for directory assistance, and I put the telephone book out on the dining